

ET RAID

HOW A DEAD
BACKYARD SPORT
BECAME INDIA'S
SECOND-BIGGEST
SPECTACLE AND
A BLUEPRINT FOR
EVERY LEAGUE THAT
FOLLOWED



IN 2014, WHEN the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) was launched, kabaddi barely existed as a business. It survived largely as a barefoot school-ground sport pushed to the margins by cricket. Its only regular global visibility came through the Asian Games, where it has been a medal event for men since 1990 and women since 2010. Yet PKL's opening season drew 435 million viewers, more than the Hockey World Cup and the FIFA World Cup combined that year.

By 2026, PKL had become India's second most-watched sports league, as per KPMG report, ahead of hockey and football, with the league valued at more than ₹1,000 crore by industry experts.

No sport in India has travelled that far, that fast, from forgotten village game to thousand-crore business. Almost nobody thought it was possible.

THE GAME NOBODY WANTED TO PLAY

The idea began as an experiment inside the Mahindra & Mahindra